ISO 37002
Whistleblowing management systems

Checklist

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ISO 37002 – Whistleblowing management systems checklist

ISO 37002 provides guidance on setting up and managing whistleblowing systems within organisations. As expectations around transparency and reporting continue to grow, aligning with this standard helps ensure your processes are effective and trusted.

This checklist highlights the key steps to build a whistleblowing management system based on ISO 37002.

Step 1:

Assess the current state of your whistleblowing management system

Your organisation will likely have some form of reporting process in place. This can be formal (an established hotline, web applications, in-person reporting processes) or informal (written guidance on reporting to your manager in case potentially detrimental conduct is observed). The new management system must be developed and communicated effectively so that employees can see reporting as a legitimate and trusted option for voicing their concerns.

To determine how well your current system is working, you will need to gather information such as:

- the number of reports being made
- the types of issues
- possible reasons for a lack of reports
- whether the organisation acted on reports
- whether there were any failures in responding to good-faith reports.

Step 2:

Define the context and scope of your whistleblowing management system

You will need to consider the specific needs and risks associated with your industry and workforce. For example, a mining company will need tools and applications that can be accessed in multiple languages, with reporting channels that are suitable and accessible for workers in rural or distant locations, and with wide distribution, given how impactful mining issues are to local communities and the organisation's overall reputation. A triage system should also be in place to ensure that out-of-scope issues (such as workplace grievances) are delegated to the appropriate personnel for review.

To define the organisation's context and scope, you must consider its:

- size and structure
- locations
- languages
- business model
- accessibility issues
- business and risk profile, from a public interest perspective.

Step 3:

Get leadership commitment

Top management and the governing body should endorse and promote the whistleblowing management system by:

- approving a whistleblowing policy (see Step 4)
- promoting a 'speak-up' culture to encourage reporting
- promising non-retaliation
- promoting the concepts of confidentiality and anonymity in reporting (where applicable)
- working with appropriate teams to ensure the whistleblowing management system meets organisational values and objectives.

Step 4:

Set up a whistleblowing policy

The whistleblowing policy will help govern the reporting programme and overall management system.

Some necessary attributes of the policy include:

- defining the scope of the reporting programme (see Step 2)
- prohibiting negative or detrimental conduct
- promoting a speak-up culture
- ensuring trust, impartiality and protection throughout an investigation
- outlining how a potential investigation works so employees know what to expect
- explaining how to access reporting channels
- identifying a compliance function or other team that individuals can go to with questions.

Step 5:

Define roles, responsibilities and authority

To support and lead effective reporting, the organisation needs a whistleblowing management function.

Establishing this function will often include:

- hiring individuals with expertise in reporting, either within an existing compliance function or in a separate team to ensure impartiality
- empowering the team to receive, assess, address and review incoming reports
- providing appropriate training
- investing in technology applications (such as Speeki)
- underscoring the importance of individual voices to create change within the organisation.

Step 6:

Create a plan for the management system

A plan should be in place to ensure that objectives are tracked, managed and delegated, with results and outcomes communicated as needed.

Example goals and objectives for the whistleblowing management system plan might focus on:

- encouraging reporting
- supporting whistleblowers
- dealing with reports in a timely manner
- improving organisational culture
- reducing potential wrongdoing
- distributing the whistleblowing policy to all employees
- providing training on the policy
- implementing technological tools to support reporting channels
- discussing and empowering line managers to receive reports directly from employees.

Step 7:

Generate awareness and provide training

Personnel should be made aware of:

- how to report

- how to identify potential wrongdoing or detrimental conduct
- who they can voice concerns to
- how to access guidance documents such as the code of conduct
- the fact that they can report directly to authorities.

Management and leadership should also be trained on these concepts, with additional focus on:

- how reports will be reviewed
- the potential implications to the organisation if wrongdoing occurs
- the importance of impartiality and confidentiality
- how and where documents related to reports and investigations are maintained.

Step 8:

Create a documentation plan

Since whistleblowing involves sensitive information, the organisation must maintain a documentation system.

This system should include:

- maintaining documentation related to the management system in accordance with the organisation's data retention policies
- ensuring only appropriate personnel can access investigation documents
- managing data in accordance with relevant data protection laws, especially given that reports could contain personally identifiable information.

Step 9:

Set rules around confidentiality

The whistleblowing management system must preserve the confidentiality of the reporter and the involved subjects. As a result, investigatory processes and tools should be managed to retain confidentiality.

The management system should apprise reporters of additional factors related to confidentiality, such as:

- rules around anonymity
- the effects of confidentiality on investigatory effectiveness
- the impact on communication when reports are made anonymously.

Step 10:

Set up and manage reporting channels

All whistleblowing systems must be able to receive, assess, address and close out any reports received.

To receive reports effectively:

- ensure there are multiple reporting channels
- provide notification and feedback to reporters about confidentiality and next steps.

To assess reports effectively:

- engage with other functions
- gather further information
- take preliminary measures
- inform authorities if required
- conclude the case if possible
- provide updates to the reporter
- assess the risk of detriment to the whistleblower – this could include consideration of things like whether detrimental action is already occurring or will occur soon, whether there are multiple types of wrongdoing and how the information was obtained.

To address reports effectively:

- follow due process
- ensure adequate resourcing
- set clear terms of reference and scope for the investigation
- document everything
- maintain an audit trail
- ensure the investigation does not interfere with a judicial proceeding
- protect evidence
- manage data securely.

To conclude a case, ensure you:

- issue findings
- take disciplinary action
- document learnings
- retain documented information in accordance with your data retention policy
- refer the matter to authorities if required.

Step 11:

Monitor, measure and evaluate the whistleblowing management system

As part of performance evaluation, organisations should:

- maintain indicators for evaluation, which could include the number of reports, the average time to respond or close out a case, the types of issues raised, and surveys regarding awareness of the reporting system
- annually audit the reporting and whistleblowing system
- have the management system regularly reviewed by top management, ensuring it meets objectives, has adequate resources and competently manages issues raised by employees.

Step 12:

Seek continual improvement

Based on reviews conducted by internal audit and top management, you will need to resolve any potential non-conformities or areas of improvement.

Consider how the management system can be improved moving forward, such as by:

- increasing access to reporting channels
- increasing awareness of reporting tools
- resolving issues faster
- decreasing any prevalent issues
- improving business operations as a result of resolving certain issues.

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About Speeki

Speeki helps companies build, manage, report on and assure ESG initiatives, turning challenges into opportunities with AI-driven software and solutions.

Our all-in-one Speeki® platform empowers companies to manage ESG and sustainability programmes, boost corporate sustainability due diligence in line with directives like the CSDDD, and streamline reporting under GRI, ESRS, IFRS (S1 and S2) and more.

Beyond software, Speeki offers ESG assurance and ISO certifications covering over 20 ESG topics.

Our mission is to build a more sustainable world by helping companies achieve their sustainability goals, meet regulatory requirements and address stakeholder expectations, driving long-term value at every stage of their ESG journey.

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